

FEARLESS

Blue denotes ppt slide

Brown denotes instructions to technician

TEXT: 2 Timothy 1:1-14 (KJV) *“Paul, an apostle of Jesus Christ by the will of God, according to the promise of life which is in Christ Jesus, ² To Timothy, my dearly beloved son: Grace, mercy, and peace, from God the Father and Christ Jesus our Lord. ³ I thank God, whom I serve from my forefathers with pure conscience, that without ceasing I have remembrance of thee in my prayers night and day; ⁴ Greatly desiring to see thee, being mindful of thy tears, that I may be filled with joy; ⁵ When I call to remembrance the unfeigned faith that is in thee, which dwelt first in thy grandmother Lois, and thy mother Eunice; and I am persuaded that in thee also. ⁶ Wherefore I put thee in remembrance that thou stir up the gift of God, which is in thee*

by the putting on of my hands. ⁷ For God hath not given us the spirit of fear; but of power, and of love, and of a sound mind.

⁸ Be not thou therefore ashamed of the testimony of our Lord, nor of me his prisoner: but be thou partaker of the afflictions of the gospel according to the power of God; ⁹ Who hath saved us, and called us with an holy calling, not according to our works, but according to his own purpose and grace, which was given us in Christ Jesus before the world began, ¹⁰ But is now made manifest by the appearing of our Saviour Jesus Christ, who hath abolished death, and hath brought life and immortality to light through the gospel: ¹¹ Whereunto I am appointed a preacher, and an apostle, and a teacher of the Gentiles. ¹² For the which cause I also suffer these things: nevertheless I am not ashamed: for I know whom I have believed, and am persuaded that he is able to keep that which I have committed unto him

against that day. ¹³ Hold fast the form of sound words, which thou hast heard of me, in faith and love which is in Christ Jesus. ¹⁴ That good thing which was committed unto thee keep by the Holy Ghost which dwelleth in us.”

INTRO: *Fearless* is a 1993 American drama film directed by Peter Weir and starring Jeff Bridges, Isabella Rossellini, Rosie Perez and John Turturro. The movie was written by Rafael Yglesias from his novel of the same name and was filmed entirely in California.

In this movie Max (Played by Jeff Bridges) boards an ill-fated flight from San Francisco to Houston and consequently the plane crashes killing almost everyone aboard. Following the crash Max comes to believe he is invincible, even immortal only to later discover that he is not.

None of us are invincible or immortal but we are also told not to be afraid of our own shadows!

The word fearless means, not afraid, very brave, without fear, courageous.

Fearless synonyms:

- Bold...
- [Courageous](#)...
- [Gutsy](#)...
- Heroic...
- Intrepid...
- [Manful](#)...
- Stalwart...
- [Undaunted](#)...
- Valiant...

Fearless antonyms:

- Chicken...
- [Chickenhearted](#)...
- [Chicken-livered](#)...

- Cowardly...
- Fainthearted...
- Fearful...
- Gutless...
- Lily-livered...
- Nerveless...
- Spineless...
- Spiritless...
- Timorous...
- Weak-hearted...
- Yellow...

Paul refers to fear in this way, “*the spirit of fear*”. This is a very interesting statement indeed. Fear is a spirit?

Two very important facts about fear:

- Fear is an emotion... Fear as an emotion is when someone scares you, or you are frightened by a sudden circumstance.

- Fear is a spirit... Fear as a spirit is when there is constant ongoing fear with regard to a thing.

If fear is a spirit we know it is not a spirit from God, “***God has not given us the spirit of fear***”. If God does not give us the spirit of fear, where does this spirit originate? It comes from hell and is of the devil!

Fear is referred to as a specific spirit, “***the spirit of fear***”. At one time or another we have all been the target and victim of the spirit of fear.

Wikipedia say's, phobias are irrational fears of things and situations which can be a danger but most are not harmful.

Here is a partial listing of such fears:

- [Ablutophobia](#) - Fear of [bathing](#), [washing](#), or [cleaning](#)
- [Achluophobia](#) – Fear of [darkness](#)

- Acrophobia – Fear of heights
- Agyrophobia – Fear of crossing the road
- Bananaphobia – Fear of bananas
- Belomophobia – Fear of needles
- Bibliophobia – Fear of books
- Cacophobia - Fear of ugliness
- Catoptrophobia – Fear of mirrors
- Chionophobia – Fear of snow
- Decidophobia – Fear of making a decision
- Demophobia – Fear of crowds
- Dendrophobia – Fear of trees
- Dentophobia – Fear of dentists
- Geliophobia – Fear of laughter
- Gymnophobia – Fear of nudity
- Islamophobia – Fear of Muslims
- Indophobia - Fear of Indians
- Nomophobia – Fear of losing contact with mobile phone
- Octophobia – Fear of the number eight
- Ornitophobia – Fear of birds
- Pediophobia – Fear of children

- Phengophobia – Fear of [daylight](#)
- [Philophobia](#) – Fear of [love](#)
- [Pyrophobia](#) – Fear of [fire](#)
- Taphophobia – Fear of grave and/or being buried alive
- [Zoophobia](#) – Fear of [animals](#)

The fact that fear is a spirit sounds spooky and daunting but the fact is that Jesus said in [Matthew 28:18 \(KJV\)](#) ***“And Jesus came and spake unto them, saying, All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth.”***
(Leave on screen until next slide)

How much power did He say? All power!
 Power:

- Over Heaven...
- Over Earth...
- Over man...
- Over animals...
- Over angels...
- Over demons...

- Over the devil...
- Over all spirits...

Now watch this... Luke 10:19 (KJV)

“Behold, I give unto you power to tread on serpents and scorpions, and over all the power of the enemy: and nothing shall by any means hurt you.” Jesus is saying that He has given the dominion that He conquered at Calvary to His people! Not just to the preachers but to every Child of God!

Ephesians 1:18-23 (CEV) *“By having the eyes of your heart flooded with light, so that you can know and understand the hope to which He has called you, and how rich is His glorious inheritance in the saints (His set-apart ones),¹⁹ And [so that you can know and understand] what is the immeasurable and unlimited and surpassing greatness of His power in and for us who believe, as demonstrated in the working of His mighty strength,²⁰ Which*

He exerted in Christ when He raised Him from the dead and seated Him at His [own] right hand in the heavenly [places], ²¹ Far above all rule and authority and power and dominion and every name that is named [above every title that can be conferred], not only in this age and in this world, but also in the age and the world which are to come. ²² And He has put all things under His feet and has appointed Him the universal and supreme Head of the church [a headship exercised throughout the church], ²³ Which is His body, the fullness of Him Who fills all in all for in that body lives the full measure of Him Who makes everything complete, and Who fills everything everywhere with Himself.”

Most of us do not have a hard time believing that Jesus rules over principalities, powers, rulers of darkness and wickedness in high places, what we have trouble believing is that we can operate in the same power and

authority, therefore we open the door to the spirit of fear. Listen again to verses 22 and 23... *And He has put all things under His feet and has appointed Him the universal and supreme Head of the church a headship exercised throughout the church,*²³ *Which is His body, the fullness of Him Who fills all in all for in that body lives the full measure of Him Who makes everything complete, and Who fills everything everywhere with Himself.”*

Ephesians 2 demonstrates how the authority Christ gathered affects the life of every believer. Ephesians 2:1-7 (CEV) *“And you [He made alive], when you were dead (slain) by [your] trespasses and sins² In which at one time you walked [habitually]. You were following the course and fashion of this world [were under the sway of the tendency of this present age], following the prince of the power of the air. [You were obedient to and under the control of] the*

[demon] spirit that still constantly works in the sons of disobedience [the careless, the rebellious, and the unbelieving, who go against the purposes of God].³ Among these we as well as you once lived and conducted ourselves in the passions of our flesh [our behavior governed by our corrupt and sensual nature], obeying the impulses of the flesh and the thoughts of the mind [our cravings dictated by our senses and our dark imaginings]. We were then by nature children of [God's] wrath and heirs of [His] indignation, like the rest of mankind.⁴ But God—so rich is He in His mercy! Because of and in order to satisfy the great and wonderful and intense love with which He loved us,⁵ Even when we were dead (slain) by [our own] shortcomings and trespasses, He made us alive together in fellowship and in union with Christ; [He gave us the very life of Christ Himself, the same new life with which He quickened Him, for] it is by

grace (His favor and mercy which you did not deserve) that you are saved (delivered from judgment and made partakers of Christ's salvation)." **(Leave this scripture on the screen until the end of the service)**

FEARLESS FAITH

Hebrews 11:1 (KJV) *"Now faith is the substance of things hoped for, the evidence of things not seen."* Hebrews 11:1 (AMP) *"Now faith is the assurance (the confirmation, the title deed) of the things [we] hope for, being the proof of things [we] do not see and the conviction of their reality [faith perceiving as real fact what is not revealed to the senses]."*

The way God sees things and the way we see things are very different. God's thoughts and our thoughts are more times than not, on two different wavelengths. We have a propensity to operate in what we can see and perceive,

but God operates at a much higher level. Fearless faith occurs when we see a thing the way God sees them. (Example of driving in a car or flying in a helicopter)

We often make decisions on our natural observation but God operates in the supernatural.

Our decisions and choices are rooted in the facts but God decides a thing based on truth.

We walk by sight (Though we are told not to), God functions in faith.

When we see things differently than God sees them we often speak out of what we see rather than what we are supposed to know.

This kind of living causes us to say one thing while God is saying something

completely different. This causes us to go against faith and operate in doubt.

Operating in doubt introduces dysfunction into our lives and causes faith to plummet, allowing our problems to eclipse our promise.

If we are going to live a life of fearless faith and receive all His benefits and see signs, miracles, and wonders we must learn to live a life of fearless faith.

The best examples of fearless faith are found in Hebrews eleven:

- Because of fearless faith ***“the elders obtained a good report.”***
- Because of fearless faith ***“Able offered unto God a more excellent sacrifice than Cain.”***
- Because of fearless faith Ables sacrifice is preaching to us today.

- Because of fearless faith Enoch cheated death.
- Because of fearless faith Noah built an ark, saved his family, and became heir of the blessings of God.
- Because of fearless faith Abraham left all and sought a better country and a better promise.
- Because of fearless faith Sarah gave birth to the promised son at ninety years old. (She conceived this promised son with a husband who was one hundred years old! Salute!!!)
- Because of fearless faith Abraham offered up his promised son Isaac as a sacrifice.
- Because of fearless faith Isaac blessed Jacob and Esau with regard to their future.
- Because of fearless faith Jacob blessed Joseph's sons.

- Because of fearless faith when he was dying, Joseph prophesied Israel's deliverance from Egypt.
- Because of fearless faith Jochebed hid Moses three months despite the Kings commandment.
- Because of fearless faith Moses ***“refused to be called the son of Pharaoh's daughter. Choosing to suffer affliction with the people of God rather than to enjoy the pleasure of sin for a season.”***
- Because of fearless faith Moses ***“forsook Egypt, not fearing the wrath of the King.”***
- Because of fearless faith Moses instituted and kept the Passover.
- Because of fearless faith Moses walked through the sea on dry ground and when the Egyptians attempted to cross, they were drowned.

- Because of fearless faith the walls of Jericho fell.
- Because of fearless faith the harlot Rahab saved herself and her family.
- Because of fearless faith; kingdoms were conquered; righteousness was obtained; promises were realized; the mouth of lions were stopped; the fire was robbed of its heat; the sword was escaped; the weak were made strong; cowards were made brave; armies fled; women received their dead raised to life; the persecuted were furnished with stamina; jail cells were opened; and those who were stoned and left for dead, lived!

God is not moved by, nor does He respond to fear or desperation. Consider this.

Following the miracle of the loaves and fish Jesus tells His disciples to get in a ship and go to the other side of the sea. Sounds

easy, right? Just because God is speaking to you is no indication that the path will be easy. Mark 6:45-52 (KJV) “*And straightway he constrained his disciples to get into the ship, and to go to the other side before unto Bethsaida, while he sent away the people.* ⁴⁶ *And when he had sent them away, he departed into a mountain to pray.* ⁴⁷ *And when even was come, the ship was in the midst of the sea, and he alone on the land.* ⁴⁸ *And he saw them toiling in rowing; for the wind was contrary unto them: and about the fourth watch of the night he cometh unto them, walking upon the sea, and would have passed by them.* ⁴⁹ *But when they saw him walking upon the sea, they supposed it had been a spirit, and cried out:* ⁵⁰ *For they all saw him, and were troubled. And immediately he talked with them, and saith unto them, Be of good cheer: it is I; be not afraid.* ⁵¹ *And he went up unto them into the ship; and the wind*

ceased: and they were sore amazed in themselves beyond measure, and wondered.
⁵² For they considered not the miracle of the loaves: for their heart was hardened.”

Jesus did not respond to fear or desperation, He responded to fearless faith. The disciples believed He was an Angel and they knew this was their only hope so they riveted their faith to the supernatural and Jesus responded by going to them and calming the storm.

Fearless faith carries with it the ability to move what we need, from the Heavenly realm to the natural realm. ***“Life and death is in the power of the tongue.”*** (O be careful little mouth what you say)

Fearless faith is that faith that goes beyond saying that God is able to believing and saying, *“He will do this...”*

Here is what fearless faith looks like in our lives:

- When confronted with difficulty, we refuse to say, *“It is impossible”*. We choose to confess... Luke 18:27 (NLT)
“What is impossible from a human perspective is possible with God.”
- When we are weary, we refuse to say, *“I am too tired to go on”*. We choose to confess... Matthew 11:28-30 (NLT)
“Come to me, all of you who are weary and carry heavy burdens, and I will give you rest. ²⁹ Take my yoke upon you. Let me teach you, because I am humble and gentle, and you will find rest for your souls. ³⁰ For my yoke fits perfectly, and the burden I give you is light.”
- When we have been betrayed in a relationship, we refuse to say, *“Nobody really loves or cares about me. I must not be good enough”*. We choose to

confess... John 3:16 (NLT) ***“For God so loved the world that he gave his only Son, so that everyone who believes in him will not perish but have eternal life.”***

- When we have exhausted our resources, we refuse to say, *“I can’t go on”*. We choose to confess... 2 Corinthians 12:9 (NLT) ***“My gracious favor is all you need. My power works best in your weakness.”*** Psalms 91:15 (NLT) ***“When they call on me, I will answer; I will be with them in trouble. I will rescue them and honor them.”***
- When we do not know which way to turn, we refuse to say, *“What should I do?”* We choose to confess... Proverbs 3:5-6 (NLT) ***“Trust in the LORD with all your heart; do not depend on your own understanding. ⁶ Seek his***

will in all you do, and he will direct your paths.”

- When we become weary with doing the right thing, we refuse to say, “*It’s not worth it*”. We choose to confess... Galatians 6:9 (NLT) “*Don’t get tired of doing what is good. Don’t get discouraged and give up, for we will reap a harvest of blessing at the appropriate time.*”
- When we have failed, we refuse to say, “*I can’t forgive myself*”. We choose to confess... 1 John 1:9 (NLT) “*If we confess our sins to him, he is faithful and just to forgive us and to cleanse us from every wrong.*” Romans 8:1 (NLT) “*There is no condemnation for those who belong to Christ Jesus.*”
- When we face financial hardships, we refuse to say, “*I can’t see a way out*”. We choose to confess... Philippians 4:19 (NLT) “*God will supply all your*

needs from his glorious riches, which have been given to us in Christ Jesus.”

- When fear presses in on us, we refuse to say, *“I am afraid of what the future holds”*. We choose to confess... 2

Timothy 1:7 (NLT) “God has not given us a spirit of fear and timidity, but of power, love, and self-discipline.”

- When we face situations that are much bigger than we are, we refuse to say, *“I am not wise enough to negotiate this mess”*. We choose to confess...

James 1:5 (NLT) “If you need wisdom—if you want to know what God wants you to do—ask him, and he will gladly tell you. He will not resent your asking.”

God’s will for everyone in this place is to move us from believing faith to fearless faith! I ask each of you are you ready to step

out on faith and believe God for the unthinkable?

FEARLESS FAMILIES

Joshua 24:14-15 (NKJV) “*Now therefore, fear the LORD, serve Him in sincerity and in truth, and put away the gods which your fathers served on the other side of the River and in Egypt. Serve the LORD!* ¹⁵ *And if it seems evil to you to serve the LORD, choose for yourselves this day whom you will serve, whether the gods which your fathers served that were on the other side of the River, or the gods of the Amorites, in whose land you dwell. But as for me and my house, we will serve the LORD.”*

Psalms 68:6 (NKJV) “*God sets the solitary in families; He brings out those who are bound into prosperity; But the rebellious dwell in a dry land.*”

In our text Joshua was laying the ground rules for possessing Canaan. Moses had just died and Joshua had been saddled with the dubious task of challenging the Israelites to actually engage in the battle for Canaan. Joshua knew that the battle for Canaan was just the first step in occupying the land for generations to come.

Joshua fully understood that the only way they could conquer the land and then occupy it over the long haul was to raise up a generation who valued righteousness and followed the commands of Jehovah. Joshua knew that if they were able to conquer Canaan, the only thing that could take the Promised Land from them was sin.

He was painfully aware that the land, and the gains they had made, would never be more than one generation from being lost. This is true in our lives. The heritage we are attempting to pass to our children is always

one generation from extinction. This is precisely why we must raise fearless families who are intent on passing this faith to the next generation.

The task of passing our faith along to our children and grandchildren is not as simple as it seems because all families have elements of dysfunction in them. ALL families! (Adam & Eve – The first family – Cain murdered Able)

The psalmist wrote to his music director and tells him that only God can bring unity to families. Psalm 68:6 (NKJV) “*God sets the solitary in families; He brings out those who are bound into prosperity; But the rebellious dwell in a dry land.*” Notice the two other things he points to here:

- When a family embraces unity, prosperity occurs.
- When unity is spurned by a family drought conditions will persist. Nothing

works right when there is conflict in a family. James 3:16 (KJV) “*Where there is strife, there is every evil work.*” To allow strife to persist in our homes is like standing on the front porch and waving evil spirits from the streets to come live with us.

My prayer for CT’ers is that our families will march in lock step, and move forward shoulder to shoulder in pursuit of being a fearless family.

Characteristics of fearless families:

- Everyone is serving Jesus...
- Everyone is filled with the Spirit...
- Family devotions are a matter of routine...
- The tithe is joyfully returned to the church...
- Faithful church attendance in non-negotiable...

- Serving in ministry through the church is a matter of course...
- Being involved in outreach is a family activity...

Lets take a look at the devastating consequences of failing to build fearless families of faith:

1) King David – David had an affair with a married woman, then had her husband killed. The son from this union died in infancy. Amnon, a son of King David raped Tamar, his half sister who was King David's daughter. Absalom was so infuriated at Amnon who was his half brother, that he killed him and then fled for his own life.

A few years later, King David decided to forgive Absalom. Absalom came home and made peace with his father but the reconciliation was short lived. A much more serious conflict between King David and Absalom arose because Absalom realized

that he was not going to be heir to the throne. Absalom gathered up his followers and tried to kill his father so that he might be king.

King David found himself running for his life. David's army defeated Absalom's army. Even though he had been the target of Absalom's murderous ways, David told his Generals to treat Absalom gently. In his defeat Absalom's long hair got caught in some tree branches and Absalom was dangling in midair and David's soldiers found him and killed him.

Upon hearing the news, King David became very sad. 2 Samuel 18:33 (NKJV) *“Then the king was deeply moved, and went up to the chamber over the gate, and wept. And as he went, he said thus: “O my son Absalom—my son, my son Absalom—if only I had died in your place! O Absalom my son, my son!”* Absalom did not need a

father to die in his place; he needed a dad that was a better parent than a king. He needed a father that knew how to take family matters into his own hands and if necessary say no, and make it stick. Being able to pronounce the word no is a critical element in raising fearless families of faith.

David raised his family far different than Jesse raised him! When David killed Goliath, Saul did not ask who David was, he said “*Whose son is this?*” He was really saying, “*I want to meet the dad that can raise a son like this.*” I must ask us, when people meet our children what are they wondering about us? I am issuing a challenge to all CT parents, step up and build a fearless family of faith!

Talk about a dysfunctional family:

- Incest...
- Rape...
- Rebellion...

- Homicide...
- Domestic violence...

David was arguably the greatest King to ever rule a kingdom, but his greatness did not translate into a great father or leadership in his home.

Just because we are a great butler, baker, or candlestick maker, it does not follow that we are doing a good job of leading our homes, or being great parents!

The most important job we have is parenthood and providing Godly leadership in a family. The most important thing we will ever do is to build a fearless family of faith!

2) Eli – Eli was a priest in Israel. There is no mark on the character or conduct of Eli, and this can be said of very few Bible characters. Where Eli's life seems to go sideways is his

failure to properly conduct matters at his house. More specifically, Eli failed to tell his children no. (Very important)

The results? His sons became unethical characters. They committed illicit sexual acts with the women who came to the temple and Eli sat idly by and did not lift a finger of protest.

As a result, his sons were killed in battle, and the Philistines captured the Ark. When Eli heard this he died by falling off his chair backwards and breaking his neck. At this precise time, his daughter-in-law gave birth to a child and named him Ichabod, meaning the glory of the Lord has departed. All this because a man of God did not have the nerve to do what was necessary to make sure his family was ordered in a fearless fashion.

I want us to take a little while to look into what raising fearless families of faith looks like:

1) Noah – Noah is introduced to us as a preacher of righteousness. 2 Peter 2:5 (KJV) *“God spared not the old world, but saved Noah the eighth person, a preacher of righteousness, bringing in the flood upon the world of the ungodly.”* Genesis 6:8 (KJV) *“Noah found grace in the eyes of the Lord.”* What does it mean to be a *“Preacher of righteousness”*? A preacher is a person who is proclaiming something.

Righteousness is developing a habit of doing the right thing. I believe the Word is telling us that Noah preached and modeled right behavior for 120 years!

Noah was asked by God to build an ark that contained more than 100,000 square feet of floor space and would displace more than 22,000 tons of water as it sailed on the sea.

Noah preached 120 years and worked on the ark, but did not make one convert outside his immediate family! The good news is that he reached his entire family!

What good would it do to reach the whole world and lose your own family? Or, what would a man give in exchange for his family?

Noah built a fearless family of faith and as a result saved the human race!

2) Abraham – Abraham made a break with paganism to serve Jehovah. This God he decided to serve required him to leave his home and everything he knew to go to a mysterious place. Along the way, Jehovah required him to be willing to sacrifice his promised son for whom he had waited 100 years!

Because of his steadfast determination to follow Jehovah and pass his faith along to his offspring, he became the father of faith, as well as the father of nations! Abraham built a fearless family of faith! **Genesis 18:18-19 (KJV)** *“Abraham shall surely become a great and mighty nation, and all the nations of the earth shall be blessed in him?”* ¹⁹ *For I know him, that he will command his children and his household after him, and they shall keep the way of the LORD, to do justice and judgment; that the LORD may bring upon Abraham that which he hath spoken of him.*” Notice the benefits that flowed through the life of Abraham as a result of building fearless families of faith:

- Entire nations were blessed by Abraham
 - Jesus came through his lineage.
- God said He knew Abraham! May I ask us, what does God know about us?
- God knew that Abraham would raise up Godly seed.

- God knew Abraham's offspring would do the right thing culturally, civilly, and spiritually.
- Because Abraham and his offspring raised up fearless families of faith, God could put everything He had promised in Abraham's lane.

Think of this... When we speak about Abraham we speak not only of Abraham but of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. This process of building fearless families of faith did not begin and end with one man, but was a multi-generational undertaking. The blessing was also a trans-generational blessing. Think of it, to this day, some of the most prosperous people on the earth are of Jewish decent. (Canoe – Why were gentiles invented?)

3) Joshua - Joshua was a faithful man:

- He was emancipated from slavery in Egypt...

- He was part of the Red Sea passage...
- He distinguished himself as a leader early on... We know this because he was one of the twelve spies that went into Canaan on the initial expedition.

We know Joshua was a man of extraordinary faith because He was one of only two spies that brought back a good report of the land.

He wandered in the wilderness for forty plus years and there is not one shred of evidence that he sinned, lost his integrity, or treated anyone badly.

When Moses passed from the stage of action, Joshua was the undisputed replacement for Moses. When he became Israel's leader, he addressed the people in the following manner. [Joshua 24:14-28](#) (NKJV) ***“Now therefore, fear the LORD, serve Him in sincerity and in truth, and put***

away the gods which your fathers served on the other side of the River and in Egypt. Serve the LORD! ¹⁵ And if it seems evil to you to serve the LORD, choose for yourselves this day whom you will serve, whether the gods which your fathers served that were on the other side of the River, or the gods of the Amorites, in whose land you dwell. But as for me and my house, we will serve the LORD.” ¹⁶ So the people answered and said: “Far be it from us that we should forsake the LORD to serve other gods; ¹⁷ for the LORD our God is He who brought us and our fathers up out of the land of Egypt, from the house of bondage, who did those great signs in our sight, and preserved us in all the way that we went and among all the people through whom we passed. ¹⁸ And the LORD drove out from before us all the people, including the Amorites who dwelt in the land. We also will serve the LORD, for He is our God.” ¹⁹ But Joshua said to the people, “You cannot serve the LORD,

for He is a holy God. He is a jealous God; He will not forgive your transgressions nor your sins. ²⁰ If you forsake the LORD and serve foreign gods, then He will turn and do you harm and consume you, after He has done you good.” ²¹ And the people said to Joshua, “No, but we will serve the LORD!” ²² So Joshua said to the people, “You are witnesses against yourselves that you have chosen the LORD for yourselves, to serve Him.” And they said, “We are witnesses!” ²³ “Now therefore,” he said, “put away the foreign gods which are among you, and incline your heart to the LORD God of Israel.” ²⁴ And the people said to Joshua, “The LORD our God we will serve, and His voice we will obey!” ²⁵ So Joshua made a covenant with the people that day, and made for them a statute and an ordinance in Shechem. ²⁶ Then Joshua wrote these words in the Book of the Law of God. And he took a large stone, and set it up there under the

oak that was by the sanctuary of the LORD.

²⁷ *And Joshua said to all the people,
“Behold, this stone shall be a witness to us,
for it has heard all the words of the LORD
which He spoke to us. It shall therefore be
a witness to you, lest you deny your God.”*

²⁸ *So Joshua let the people depart, each to
his own inheritance.”* Here we learn:

- Joshua drew the line in the sand – ***“Who are you going to serve?”***
- Joshua did not permit the culture or public opinion to be a deciding factor in his own family. ***“As for me and my house we will serve the Lord.”***
- Joshua declared that if the Israelites were going to serve Jehovah they had to ***“Put away the foreign gods which are among you, and incline your heart to the LORD God of Israel.”***
- Joshua called the Israelites into a covenant commitment to serve Jehovah. ***“So Joshua made a covenant with the***

people that day, and made for them a statute and an ordinance in Shechem.”

- Joshua recorded their commitment and set up a marker as a reminder. *“Then Joshua wrote these words in the Book of the Law of God. And he took a large stone, and set it up there under the oak that was by the sanctuary of the LORD.”*
- Joshua warned the people that the stone would be a witness of their decision to follow Jehovah. *“Joshua said to all the people, “Behold, this stone shall be a witness to us, for it has heard all the words of the LORD which He spoke to us. It shall therefore be a witness to you, lest you deny your God.”*

The challenge to all CT parents:

- Draw a line in the sand with your families... (Have a family meeting)
- Make a decision today that neither the culture nor public opinion will be a

deciding factor in the direction of your family...

- Make up your mind here and now that God will be first in everything your family does...
- Write your decision down and post it in a prominent place where every family member must see it every day...

Joshua was not only a fearless leader of faith at home he was a fearless leader of faith in the workplace. There is a dire need in our culture for men and women of God to have a private persona and public persona that are the same.

FEARLESS FUTURES

Jeremiah 29:11 (NKJV) *“For I know the thoughts that I think toward you, says the LORD, thoughts of peace and not of evil, to give you a future and a hope.”* (CEV) *“I will bless you with a future filled with hope—a future of success, not of suffering.”*

Almost everyone begins life with visions and dreams of greatness, but most of us are convinced to live sub-par or mediocre existences. Why? There are probably more reasons than there are people! (A failure to make the grade in school – Being told we will never amount to anything – Being made a victim – A failed marriage – The death of a child – The termination of employment...)

While everyone has a destiny, few achieve it and many become convinced to live a sub-par existence.

I want us to think about our own futures, why we believe we were permitted to be on this earth; born to our family of origin; given the opportunities we have been afforded; confronted with the obstacles we have been forced to face?

In short, why are we here and what are we supposed to be doing? I want to throw out

what I believe to be a life changing truth:
Every single human being has been sent into
the world for a Divine purpose! 2 Timothy
1:8-9 (CEV) ***“Don’t be ashamed to speak
for our Lord. And don’t be ashamed of me,
just because I am in jail for serving him.
Use the power that comes from God and
join with me in suffering for telling the
good news. 9 God saved us and chose us to
be his holy people. We did nothing to
deserve this, but God planned it because he
is so kind. Even before time began God
planned for Christ Jesus to show kindness
to us.”***

If our existence is no accident, then we must
believe God has an eternal purpose for us.
The fulfillment of our destiny is to live out
the purpose of God in this earth, and hear
Him say well done at the successful
conclusion of our earthly sojourn!

In our CT vision statement we make it very clear that we believe we are called to redeem people to the divine purpose to which they have been called. We believe every single person has a God sized future and we would like to help you achieve it!

I can think of no other person who personifies a fearless future than does Abraham. Genesis 12:1-4 (NKJV) *“The LORD had said to Abram: “Get out of your country, From your family And from your father’s house, To a land that I will show you. ² I will make you a great nation; I will bless you And make your name great; And you shall be a blessing. ³ I will bless those who bless you, And I will curse him who curses you; And in you all the families of the earth shall be blessed.” ⁴ So Abram departed as the LORD had spoken to him, and Lot went with him. And Abram was seventy-five years old when he departed from Haran.”*

Abraham:

- Held a garage sale...
- Told his family good-bye...
- Pulled up the stakes of his tent...
- Went on an expedition of following God...

Abraham seems to have done all of this almost without a second thought. How could he go, without being furnished more detail? He was able to do such a thing because he had a God sized future.

Abraham's life was marked by questions like:

- Which direction?
- Which country?
- Which city?
- Which mountain?

God's master plan for our life is not a fast track or overnight success story but a process that is intended to end with success. Hebrews 10:36 (NKJV) *"For you have need of endurance, so that after you have done the will of God, you may receive the promise:"*

Of all the times that Abraham's future was put to the test, the greatest must have been the call of God to sacrifice his son Isaac. Genesis 22:1-2 (NKJV) *"Now it came to pass after these things that God tested Abraham, and said to him, 'Abraham!' And he said, 'Here I am.' 2 Then He said, 'Take now your son, your only son Isaac, whom you love, and go to the land of Moriah, and offer him there as a burnt offering on one of the mountains of which I shall tell you.'"* The first question that comes to mind every time I read this passage of Scripture is; how could God ask a man

who has exercised such faith for the future to do such a thing?

With this request, God was setting Abraham up to finally achieve a fearless future. From the beginning Abraham and Isaac participated in this setup:

- They readied the wagon and donkeys...
- They split the wood...
- They selected the servants...
- They packed the gear...
- They made the trip...
- They climbed the mountain...

Abraham and Isaac had:

- The wagon, the wood, and the fire...
- The transportation, the fuel, and the passion...
- The courage, the determination, and the resolve...

The only thing they lacked was the sacrifice! Abraham said, “*God will provide for himself a sacrifice*”. All they needed was:

- An ear to listen...
- The hands to help...
- The heart to respond...

If they could bring themselves to do their part, God was about to lead them step-by-step into a holy setup.

This world's system say's if we have a need, we should get a bailout. A bailout is when someone comes running to our rescue. We don't need a bailout we need a setup.

A bailout is being given something you neither planned nor worked for. A setup is something you have participated in from the beginning! Let me remind us, a bailout is the first step to slavery. (Joseph instituted a bailout in Egypt during the famine and the bailout ended in full-blown slavery)

God did not love Abraham any more than He loves us. If we will be faithful in spite of the pain and the problems God will set us up for success.

If Abraham could pass this test everything else would be academic. (Small stuff – Don't sweat the small stuff – Remember, everything is small stuff when God is involved – Don't sweat the petty stuff – Don't pet the sweaty stuff)

Abraham knew he was destined to be the father of nations. As a result, he knew nothing but his own disobedience could stand between him and his God sized future. Therefore he believed that if God required him to go through with killing his son and cremating him on the altar of sacrifice that God would raise him from the ashes.

Hebrews 11:17-19 (NKJV) ***“By faith Abraham, when he was tested, offered up***

Isaac, and he who had received the promises offered up his only begotten son,¹⁸ of whom it was said, ‘In Isaac your seed shall be called,’¹⁹ concluding that God was able to raise him up, even from the dead, from which he also received him in a figurative sense.” His submission, confidence, and obedience guided him through the most difficult trial of his life and allowed him to emerge as a hero of the faith.

You may very well be walking through the most difficult trial of your life; if so, God has a plan for your celebration of victory. Your party has already been planned; don’t give up on the brink of a miracle.

Remember, just as Abraham of old, the reason we are being called upon to face this trial, is that God is attempting to define our lives, and preparing us to occupy the fearless future He is calling us to.

Notice the actions of Abraham when he discovered the appointed mountain of testing: Genesis 22:4-6 (NKJV) *“Then on the third day Abraham lifted his eyes and saw the place afar off.⁵ And Abraham said to his young men, ‘Stay here with the donkey; the lad and I will go yonder and worship, and we will come back to you.’⁶ So Abraham took the wood of the burnt offering and laid it on Isaac his son; and he took the fire in his hand, and a knife, and the two of them went together.”*

It is interesting to me, at the point of Abrahams greatest trial he was obedient enough to the words of the Lord that he was able to call his obedient response to the seemingly ridiculous command of God: **WORSHIP!**

Faced with similar circumstances, most of us would have demanded better treatment;

complained to the pastor; quit the church; or backslid altogether.

Abraham was no quitter he was a courageous man of faith who refused to be controlled by the circumstances of the moment, rather looking to the eventuality of the journey, and a fearless future.

Those who choose to place too much emphasis on the circumstances at hand tend to suffer from chronic discouragement and are normally underachievers. Those who allow this chronic condition in their lives rarely go to mountaintops because they are so accustomed to much lower altitudes where defeat and pity are never more than one battle away. This is the place where we allow our problems to eclipse our promise.

I want to ask a question of every person in this place: Are we placing too much emphasis on the circumstances of the

moment, or are we focused on the eventuality of the journey? The answer to this question will have much bearing on whether or not we achieve the destiny God has called us to.

The bottom line is, during Abraham's expedition of finding the will of God and achieving his destiny, he reached a point where he and Isaac had to separate themselves from the crowd. [Genesis 22:4-6 \(NKJV\)](#) ***"Then on the third day Abraham lifted his eyes and saw the place afar off.5 And Abraham said to his young men, 'Stay here with the donkey; the lad and I will go yonder and worship, and we will come back to you.'6 So Abraham took the wood of the burnt offering and laid it on Isaac his son; and he took the fire in his hand, and a knife, and the two of them went together."***

Trust me, if I have made this long and grueling journey to the mountain it would be

far more difficult to convince me to stay with the donkeys than just being told one time that I couldn't go to the mountain.

These servants were a little too easy to leave behind! If they had Abraham's best interest at heart they would have been jumping up and down to accompany he and the lad to the summit of the mountain. If they were the kind of servant that had his back, he could not have gone alone.

I am about to share a leadership lesson that if followed will accelerate our fearless futures, and if ignored will certainly impede or maybe even prevent our destinies altogether:

- Everyone does not desire to go to your mountain...
- Everyone does not intend to go to your mountain...
- Everyone is not called to your mountain...

We spend far too much time and resources attempting to carry unwilling people up the mountainside of our fearless futures.
(ILLUSTRATE this)

I have attempted this for the past thirty-five years! I am tired! If you want to go to our mountain you are more than welcome. If you don't want to go, stay here with the donkeys! (If you want to soar with eagles, quit roosting with turkeys!) (I will not beg you to stay, or refuse your resignation) (What about the good shepherd and the one lost lamb? It was a lamb, not a full grown sheep!)

Can you imagine what would have occurred if Abraham had attempted to physically carry Isaac - his servants - and the wagon to the mountaintop?

He, no doubt would have tired of the journey, collapsing in one big heap of burnout and would have failed to carry out the plan of God. While Abraham would have been working hard to get everyone to the mountaintop he would have failed to reach the place of sacrifice, thus bringing him into disobedience and judgment. (Plus I would not have had anything to preach on today!)

How many good people do you suppose have fallen prey to this trick?

If those we have been traveling with are not going to the same mountain we are going to, we should leave them behind and continue our pursuit!

Kiss them goodbye, bless their STABLE aspirations, and keep climbing! (Did you hear about the horse that fell with the

jockey? The last time I heard a report they were both in STABLE condition)

In the pursuit of his destiny Abraham ascended to a height his servants could not attain. He had to separate himself from them and keep on climbing.

If we have a destiny we are focused in on there WILL come a time where separation will occur. The top of the mountain is sparsely populated, but it's worth the cost of the climb.

I can see Abe and Ike hiking up the side of the mountain talking about the things fathers and sons talk about (Fishing – hunting - hiking – camping). All of a sudden it dawned on Isaac that they did not have a sacrifice and he inquired of his father as to its whereabouts. (Kids can be extremely inquisitive – Larissa inquiring about her and Jason's birthdays).

Pay close attention to the inquiry of Isaac and the response of Abraham. *Genesis 22:7-8 (NKJV) “Isaac spoke to Abraham his father and said, ‘My father!’ And he said, ‘Here I am, my son.’ Then he said, ‘Look, the fire and the wood, but where is the lamb for a burnt offering?’⁸ And Abraham said, ‘My son, God will provide for Himself the lamb for a burnt offering.’ So the two of them went together.”* Isaac was so confident of his father’s leadership and ability to deliver on his promises that you don’t hear one more word about the whereabouts of the sacrifice! I wonder; how confident we are about our Father’s ability to make good on the fearless future to which He has called us?

Little did Isaac know that he would be involved in a very personal way, in providing a sacrifice. No one can achieve a fearless future until it has exacted from us a

very high personal price. (Story of chicken and pig – No pain, no gain – A guy in Florida who told me he has \$100 million dollars he wants to invest in ministry – He laid in bed struggling to live for 4 years – A business partner conned him out of his life's savings – Friends had to provide resources to live on during that illness)

Abraham and Isaac's fearless future involved a sacrificial step of faith. This sacrifice would exact a high price from Isaac but would exact an even higher price from Abraham. Abraham was perfectly willing to give up Isaac in his pursuit of being in the perfect center of the will of God!

Most people think that this was not too difficult for Abraham because Abraham believed that if he killed Isaac, that God would raise him from the dead. Maybe so, in fact the scripture says that he believed God would do exactly that.

Have you ever considered, even if God raised Isaac from the dead what emotional and relational damage could have been done between Abraham and Isaac from that day forward? (Trust would probably be a thing of the past)

Abraham was willing to give up his relationship with his promised son to be where God wanted him to be.

No one walks into a fearless future without strapping a sacrifice to the altar. Most of us will be called upon by God to place multiple things on the altar of sacrifice in order to attain His higher purpose.

The question must be asked; how much sacrifice is enough? The answer is until there is no chance of our being lifted up in pride when we stand victoriously on the summit of our success! T.D. Jakes said,

“The only way you will ever know how bad you want it, is to determine how much you are willing to give up to get it!” (Tee ball moms – “You gotta want it to win it – And we want it bad!)

The price of a faith filled sacrifice is never small; otherwise it would not be a sacrifice! (It would be no sacrifice at all to me to give up eating cheese or turnip greens, but it is a tremendous sacrifice to fast ten day’s)

If we are going to step into our fearless future we will likely be called upon to sacrifice something we love!

Though climbing to the peak of our destiny will not be easy, our stay at the top will be worth the climb. What would you be willing to sacrifice to go to the mountain peak of your fearless future?

If we fail the faithfulness test we will have to settle for a bailout. A bailout is:

- A banker...
- A lawyer...
- A doctor...
- A preacher...
- A marriage counselor...

All of these people are important at intervals in our lives and they can orchestrate a bailout, but it takes divine intervention to bring about a setup! (Try Jesus He never fails)

Not everyone can participate in a setup. Some folks seem to find a way to mess-up a set-up. I believe God spoke to me and said the reason Abraham did not take his servants, and the reason they never asked to go is because they would have interfered, rather than participated in the setting of the stage for the miracle and act of divine love

God was about to demonstrate to his
FRIEND Abraham!!

People who are more comfortable with a
bailout than a setup will:

- Crash rather than climb...
- Complain rather than confess...
- Sit rather than shout...
- Get bitter rather than better...

Isaac said, *“Father, here is the wood, and
here is the fire, but where is the sacrifice?”*

The manner in which Isaac sees the
circumstances is much different than the
way Abraham sees them. What is the
difference? T.D. Jakes said *“A boy can see
the stuff, but a man knows how to put it all
together!”* (The Swing set)

God has given us the stuff, all we have to do
is put it all together according to his
instructions, and within his timing.

Even a man must have the help of the Lord in putting all of the pieces together, thus unveiling the picture God had in mind from the beginning! God knew me before I was born, and planned each day of my life!

Jeremiah 29:11 (CEV) “*I will bless you with a future filled with hope—a future of success, not of suffering.*”

God provided for Abraham the stuff for a sacrifice but it was up to him to put it all together. This was not a bailout: it was a setup.

Abraham planned to sacrifice his son, but God had another plan. When he raised the knife to take the life of his son, God spoke to him about a ram caught in a thicket behind him.

A ram is uniquely designed to negotiate briar patches without being trapped by them. What in the world is wrong with this ram?

The briar patch didn't trap the ram. His GPS (God Positioning System) had a full signal. This ram had not experienced a lack of stamina an angel was holding him by his horns in a thicket!

Think about it, Abraham had stomped all over this mountain getting just the right rocks. He and Isaac have no doubt had a conversation (Maybe even a heated exchange) about what was about to transpire and this ram never made a sound? This was a holy setup!

I believe Abraham was so glad to see this ram that he felt like kissing him right on the lips in spite of the fact that the ram had chronic halitosis! Have you ever been there? God provided a substitute for you! A ram for a son, a son for a sin! There is no better substitute!

Is God free to pull off a setup in our lives at a moments notice? In order to receive a setup rather than a bailout we have to be capable of transitioning at a moments notice. Miracles are made in moments of flexibility!

Abraham had offered dozens if not hundreds of sacrifices and not one time had God taken one sacrifice down to offer a different sacrifice. What would have happened if Abraham had been too set in his way's to believe the very God who would require such a sacrifice could also raise his dead son to life? The Bible say's that Isaac was "*As good as dead*" to Abraham!

Some of us can't receive get to our fearless future because:

- We don't believe a righteous God would require a sacrifice from us...
- We have strapped the wrong sacrifice to the altar...

- We don't know God at the resurrection level...
- We can't believe God can provide a substitute at the last minute...

Fear of the future and fear of failure:

- Businesses fail...
- Nations crumble...
- Marriages end in divorce...
- Careers are brought to an abrupt halt...
- Denominations lose their effectiveness...
- Ministries cease to be effective...
- People walk away from God, never to return...

(Story about Swiss watchmakers refusing to adapt to the quartz watch - Has led to sharing a very small part of the market, and extremely reduced profit margins)

When we are in hot pursuit of a fearless destiny we will eventually reach a place that we discover a sacrifice tied up in a thicket. Sounds good, right? The only problem is that a ram in a thicket only occurs when we are at our point of greatest desperation.

Before we can see the ram we have to stare down:

- Every critic...
- Every detractor...
- Every devil and demon...
- Every negative assignment...

This is a requirement for those who are determined seize a fearless future.

I want to challenge us to go out and step boldly into the fearless future God has envisioned for each of us.

Isaiah 54:17 (NKJV) “*No weapon formed against you shall prosper, And every*

*tongue which rises against you in judgment
You shall condemn. This is the heritage of
the servants of the LORD, And their
righteousness is from Me,” Says the
LORD.”*

Deuteronomy 33:26-29 (NKJV) *“There is
no one like the God of Jeshurun, Who
rides the heavens to help you, And in His
excellency on the clouds. ²⁷ The eternal God
is your refuge, And underneath are the
everlasting arms; He will thrust out the
enemy from before you, And will say,
‘Destroy!’ ²⁸ Then Israel shall dwell in
safety, The fountain of Jacob alone, In a
land of grain and new wine; His heavens
shall also drop dew. ²⁹ Happy are you, O
Israel! Who is like you, a people saved by
the LORD, The shield of your help And the
sword of your majesty! Your enemies shall
submit to you, And you shall tread down
their high places.”*

Psalm 60:12 (NKJV) *“Through God we will do valiantly, For it is He who shall tread down our enemies.”*

FEARLESS FINANCES

Luke 6:38 (KJV) *“Give, and it shall be given unto you; good measure, pressed down, and shaken together, and running over, shall men give into your bosom. For with the same measure that ye mete withal it shall be measured to you again.”* Luke

6:38 (NLT) *“If you give, you will receive. Your gift will return to you in full measure, pressed down, shaken together to make room for more, and running over.*

Whatever measure you use in giving—large or small—it will be used to measure what is given back to you.”

God has set into order some laws, one of which is the Law of the Harvest. According to the Word of God, this law is irrefutable.

Galatians 6:7-10 (NLT) *“**Don’t be misled.***

Remember that you can't ignore God and get away with it. You will always reap what you sow! 8 Those who live only to satisfy their own sinful desires will harvest the consequences of decay and death. But those who live to please the Spirit will harvest everlasting life from the Spirit. 9 So don't get tired of doing what is good. Don't get discouraged and give up, for we will reap a harvest of blessing at the appropriate time. 10 Whenever we have the opportunity, we should do good to everyone, especially to our Christian brothers and sisters.” Any good farmer understands and respects this simple principle. A farmer who makes his living from the soil:

- Prepares the soil...
- Plows...
- Plants...
- Fertilizes...
- Carefully oversees...
- Seeks to protect...

I Pastored for a number of years in a farming community, and the lessons I learned from those farmers has greatly enhanced my ability and willingness to give to the Lord. I am convinced that God wants to bless and prosper ALL of His people.

The reasons for people not being blessed are too many to mention but here is a few of the most common reasons:

- Failure to tithe... This is a trust issue and right here is where most people launch into a life of fearless finances or they fail to launch and never have the faith to step into the blessings of God.
- Failure to properly manage... This has to do with the habit of running into debt. Debt is not sin it is slavery! **Proverbs 22:7 (NKJV) “*The rich rules over the poor, And the borrower is servant to the lender.*”**

- Failure to sow into the right soil... No farmer sows into soil that is lacking in all the nutrients needed to produce a harvest. The farmer spends all his time between harvest and sowing getting the ground ready for the seed he is intending to plant.
- Failure to know when to sow... The farmer also knows when to sow. He doesn't plant soy beans in November. The farmer is so intentional about when a seed is to be sown that he refuses to sow just because the almanac say's so. He makes sure the soil is the right temperature.

If we want our financial life to operate in the arena of the fearless we must know how to sow, where to sow, and when to sow.

One of the dumbest lessons ever taught in a church is "*Give without expecting anything in return.*" Someone please show me that in

the Bible. I have never heard a crazier statement in my life!

I have yet to meet a farmer who sows his fields without expecting the ground to produce a return. Every farmer expects an increase in due season, and we should give with an expectation of getting something in return.

The farmer who sows without expecting to receive will be out of business in short order.

A believer should give because his heart demands it, yet he receives because he gave. Luke 6:38 (NLT) *“If you give, you will receive. Your gift will return to you in full measure, pressed down, shaken together to make room for more, and running over. Whatever measure you use in giving—large or small—it will be used to measure what is given back to you.”*

In the Old Testament farmers were instructed to leave some grain in the corners of their fields for the poor to gather. Each year at harvest-time there were two sets of harvesters in the field, the primary harvesters which worked the middle of the field were actually hired by the landowner to help bring in the harvest; and the poor people in the corners of the field which were harvesting grain to sustain their families.

The harvesters in the middle of the field would fill their baskets and walk to the barn or wagon and empty the grain and go back to the middle of the field to repeat the process. Because they were being paid by the hour it did not matter to this group of harvesters how full their basket was, they were working until the harvest was reaped. They just needed to stay busy until the job was done. The next set of harvesters had a completely different motivation, they were

poor and had probably traveled a great distance to be in the field and all they would be able to bring home for their families is what they could get in their basket!

The contents of the basket were a matter of life and death to them! Because this was a matter of survival the poor would not just fill their basket half full, and leave the field, they would press-it-down, shake-it-together to make room for more, and heap-it-up again. (ILLUSTRATE THIS)

Watch now... Here is the giving and getting lesson... ***“Whatever measure you use in giving—large or small—it will be used to measure what is given back to you.”***

(ILLUSTRATE this with a spoon – A ladel – A scoop shovel)

These are the words of Jesus not a television preacher. Remember, this is not exclusively about money, He is speaking of loving, loaning, having compassion, dispensing

kindness, providing mercy, AND giving money.

When a farmer sows he always receives more than he started with. (ILLUSTRATE this with an ear of corn)

Even in the year when the farmer is purported to have a complete crop failure he gets more than he gives. While giving is our motivation rather than getting, the law of the harvest has been pre-determined, we will get more than we give.

A foundational truth for all Christ centered givers is this: Everything we have belongs to God; we are the stewards (Business Managers) of His possessions.

If we truly view ourselves merely as stewards, it makes it much easier to distribute His wealth in a responsible manner. However if we view the

possessions we have been blessed with as our own we tend to:

- Guard it...
- Hoard it...
- Protect it...
- Keep it...

ILLUSTRATION: (Ask for someone to give me a \$100.00 bill...) Why was this person so quick to give me a \$100.00 bill? Because I gave it to him before the service and told him I wanted it back during my sermon. He experienced no remorse, grief, or emotional conflict about giving the money to me! Why? It wasn't his to begin with, it belonged to me, and he was just holding it until I asked for it back.

When we understand that we are stewards, not owners it is much easier to take the actions necessary to live a life of fearless faith with regard to our finances.

One of the greatest deterrents to living a life of fearless finances is that we are natural born takers. While we are natural born takers, the nature of God is to give. **John 3:16 (KJV) “*For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting life.*”** I cannot refrain from asking this question, “*If the nature of God is to give and we have been born again by His spirit, shouldn’t we become spiritual born givers?*”

If we are going to live a life of fearless finances we must settle the issue of not being able to out-give God.

I have CHOSEN to operate in the gift of giving – Over the years I have been among the top givers in the church, even when there were people who made much more than I did. Many years I have been the top giver in the church. Very few people in this church

will out give me. I will always give more to my family than I receive. No one on this staff will out work me. Not because I have a need for being number one but because I have the gift of giving.

When Susan and I had our taxes prepared for 2013 we had given a little more than 30% of our income to the Kingdom of God. We are living a life of fearless finances and I invite you to join us.

If some of you set your mind to do so you could no doubt out give me because you have more resources available to you. One thing is for sure you cannot out give God because he has the heart and resources to make sure that does not happen.

To begin with, how would we ever purpose to give a greater gift than He gave when He sent His son to this earth to die for our sins?

He has bound Himself to His Word to out give every single individual. Mark 10:29-30 (KJV) *“And Jesus answered and said, Verily I say unto you, There is no man that hath left house, or brethren, or sisters, or father, or mother, or wife, or children, or lands, for my sake, and the gospel’s, 30 But he shall receive an hundredfold now in this time, houses, and brethren, and sisters, and mothers, and children, and lands, with persecutions; and in the world to come eternal life.”*”

Living a life of fearless faith with regard to our finances requires:

- Trust...
- Faith...
- Courage...
- Stick-to-it-ness...

How many of you want to be blessed and have financial security? Being blessed

Means to have supernatural power working on our behalf. How many of you like the sound of that?

It should follow that being cursed means having supernatural power working against us. If a person has supernatural power working for them, there is no way they can fail. Conversely, a person who has supernatural power working against them cannot succeed no matter how many resources they have at their disposal!

The surest way to get blessed is to do all that His word has commanded us to do. The surest way to get a curse on our lives is to refuse to do what the Word of God has to say. Listen to what the Word say's about tithing. **Malachi 3:8-9 (KJV) “*Will a man rob God? Yet ye have robbed me. But ye say, Wherein have we robbed thee? In tithes and offerings. 9 Ye are cursed with a***

curse: for ye have robbed me, even this whole nation.”

ILLUSTRATION:

Have Doug Turnbull come up for an interview:

- If a person steals money from the bank, what happens?
- Would the fact that the person was going through hard times give them immunity?
- Would their relationship with you keep them from being prosecuted?
- Will the bank expect restitution?

Would you agree that a person who knowingly and willfully robs a bank should be prosecuted and pay the penalty? When we knowingly and willfully steal from Gods storehouse we willingly place ourselves in a position of calling on supernatural powers to work against us. If supernatural powers are at work against us, we cannot succeed.

If we hope to live a fearless life of fearless faith with regard to our finances we must put first things first. In so doing, God must occupy the number one slot in our lives. The way we handle our money speaks volumes about where our priorities have been placed. Matthew 6:19-21 (NLT) ***“Don’t store up treasures here on earth, where they can be eaten by moths and get rusty, and where thieves break in and steal. 20 Store your treasures in heaven, where they will never become moth-eaten or rusty and where they will be safe from thieves. 21 Wherever your treasure is, there your heart and thoughts will also be.”***

I know there will be people who will say that I should have used some other subject to establish where our priorities should be placed, but did you know that there are, 500 Scriptures in the Bible concerning prayer; 500 verses concerning faith; and more than 2,000 Scriptures concerning money and

possessions? Jesus talked about money in 16 of His 38 parables! Money is actually a test from God. It is a priority test! Are we passing or failing?

I want to talk to you about the principle of first fruits. This precedent was established in the Old Testament book of Exodus. [Exodus 13:2,12,13 \(NLT\)](#) ***“Dedicate to me all the firstborn sons of Israel and every firstborn male animal. They are mine.”*** ***12 All firstborn sons and firstborn male animals must be presented to the LORD. 13 A firstborn male donkey may be redeemed from the LORD by presenting a lamb in its place. But if you decide not to make the exchange, the donkey must be killed by breaking its neck. However, you must redeem every firstborn son.”***

God declared the firstborn belonged to Him 16 times in Scripture. According to Old Testament Law the firstborn was to be

sacrificed or redeemed. There was no third choice.

When an animal delivered the firstborn it was to be sacrificed and if for some reason it was considered unclean, the person was to take a clean animal from their herd and sacrifice it, thus redeeming the firstborn.

Jesus was Gods firstborn and He offered him as a sacrifice. He was a real first fruits offering, in that sense He was Gods tithe. God gave His tithe in faith before we ever believed. Romans 5:8 (NLT) ***“But God showed his great love for us by sending Christ to die for us while we were still sinners.”*** Romans 8:29 (NLT) ***“For God knew his people in advance, and he chose them to become like his Son, so that his Son would be the firstborn, with many brothers and sisters.”***

The Scripture is clear, God not only requires the firstborn or the first fruit, but He set the example by giving His firstborn Son, for the sins of His other sons.

In the same way, we are to bring the first-fruit and THEN we will see the blessing. The first fruit allows us to participate in a life of fearless finances.

Some people want to wait until they can afford to start tithing, but the curse and the devourer will never allow them to be in a financial position to do so. I recently had a conversation with a person who was not tithing and I told them that it did not matter how much money came into their lives they would never have enough because they would always be carrying their resources in a sack with holes in it!

ILLUSTRATION: Use a bank bag with holes in it. I will constantly pour coins into it

and act frustrated because I do not understand why I cannot fill it up.

ILLUSTRATION: Use a bag without holes in it. See the difference?

It is interesting to note that God required the firstborn. He did not say to allow the ewe to bear nine lambs and then give number ten to God. He said give the firstborn to Him.

The prophet told the widow to bake him a cake first and when she did, the meal in the barrel never failed to be present. It is possible to be a tither without adhering to the principle of first fruits.

Why did God go beyond requiring the tithe to requiring the first fruit? Because it doesn't take faith to give one out of ten, but it requires great faith to give the first fruit and believe Him to multiply it ten times!

Giving the last tenth allows for no adventure, but giving the first tenth brings the tight rope of fearless finances into play.

Have you ever wondered how God could justify taking the lives of the first born in Egypt? This is because they already belonged to Him. They had not been released to Him through human authority, but they were His to do whatever He wanted.

Remember this: God is going to get what belongs to Him; if I release it to Him I get blessed; if I refuse to release it to Him He will get His another way, and I place myself under a curse for not being obedient!

The first born in Israel didn't die that night did they? Why not? Because God redeemed the firstborn with a spotless lamb! [Exodus 12:7,13 \(NLT\) “*They are to take some of the lamb’s blood and smear it on the top*](#)

and sides of the doorframe of the house where the lamb will be eaten. 13 The blood you have smeared on your doorposts will serve as a sign. When I see the blood, I will pass over you. This plague of death will not touch you when I strike the land of Egypt.”

Have you ever wondered why God respected Abel’s offering but rejected Cain’s? Genesis 4:3-5 (KJV) “*And in process of time it came to pass, that Cain brought of the fruit of the ground an offering unto the LORD. 4 And Abel, he also brought of the firstlings of his flock and of the fat thereof. And the LORD had respect unto Abel and to his offering: 5 But unto Cain and to his offering he had not respect. And Cain was very wroth, and his countenance fell.*”

Abel brought the firstborn; Cain brought his offering in the process of time; when he decided to; when he got around to it!

Let me ask you some soul theological questions?

- Why did God require that everything in Jericho be destroyed? Because it was the first city conquered in the Promised Land. It was the first fruit.
- Why did Achan get into so much trouble for taking a little gold, silver and clothing from the city? Because he was attempting to rob God of the first fruit!

Remember this: “*Any first thing given is never lost, any first thing not given is always lost.*” (Robert Morris) In other words what we give to God is never lost because He redeems it for us, but what we withhold from him will always be lost.

The reason for the loss is that our possessions no longer have the redemptive power of God working for them. God cannot and will not be in partnership with anyone or anything that engages in the practice of

theft. Such an activity would be a violation of His moral law! Matthew 16:25 (NLT) ***“If you try to keep your life for yourself, you will lose it. But if you give up your life for me, you will find true life.”***

If we are going to live fearless lives of faith with regard to our finances we must make sure the first fruit of our lives belong to God:

- Our devotion...
- Our time...
- Our talent...
- Our possessions...
- Our finances...

What are we to do with the first fruit?

Proverbs 3:9-10 (NKJV) ***“Honor the LORD with your possessions, And with the first-fruits of all your increase; 10 So your barns will be filled with plenty, And your vats will overflow with new wine.”*** These verses point out the following principles:

- Tithing is a priority of God... ***“Honor the Lord with your possessions...”***
- First fruits are required... Honor him, ***“...With the first fruits of your increase...”***
- We will experience Gods provision... ***“Your barns will be filled with plenty...”***
- We can expect Him to bless us in a spiritual sense... ***“Your vats will overflow with new wine...”***

Just as the firstborn and first fruit belong to God, the tithe belongs to Him as well.

Leviticus 27:30 (NKJV) ***“And all the tithe of the land, whether of the seed of the land or of the fruit of the tree, is the LORD’s. It is holy to the LORD.”***

Some will say this is an Old Testament principle, but in reality, it is a God principle.

Malachi 3:6 (NKJV) ***“For I am the LORD, I do not change...”*** Romans 11:16 (NKJV)

“For if the first-fruit is holy, the lump is also holy; and if the root is holy, so are the branches.” Matthew 23:23 (NLT) “How terrible it will be for you teachers of religious law and you Pharisees. Hypocrites! For you are careful to tithe even the tiniest part of your income, but you ignore the important things of the law—justice, mercy, and faith. You should tithe, yes, but you should not leave undone the more important things.”

Cain and Able were offering first fruit to God and Abraham paid tithe four hundred years before the law was given.

Many blessings are promised to those who become tithers but the first fruit offering is the trigger on the blessing. I hope you will pull the trigger today!

At times in my life I have been in a quandary concerning the enormous blessing

that is pronounced upon tithing, “***Not enough room to receive it.***”

As far as I can tell this blessing is to the corporate church when we all engage in the practice of tithing. Think of what could be done in the Kingdom and for the community if everyone in the church were a tither.

(80% - 20%) This means we are only functioning at a 20% rate of efficiency. I do not know of one business that could survive that. The church is greatly diminished because of it as well.

CONCLUSION:

If we desire to live a life of fearless faith with regard to our finances we must do the following things:

- Tithe the first fruit (10%) of our total family income...
- Tithe the first fruit to our local church...

- Give the first fruit freely and never designate it...
- Make sure the first fruit is in God's house before one dime of the income is spent...

When we do these things we will embark on a life of fearless faith with regard to our finances. A believer who is living a life of fearless finances can expect:

- The exploration of new territory...
- The discovery of new horizons...
- The unearthing of new blessings...

I dare you to try what I have been teaching you over the past few weeks.